Volunteer Handbook

How the literacy, numeracy and science sessions fit together, and how to run a good class

WHAT THIS PACKAGE IS
A set of ready-to-use lesson plans, worksheets and reference sheets for teaching children Bengali literacy, numeracy and basic science. Each lesson has a volunteer guide (what to say and do), a student worksheet (to print) and an answer key. Everything exists in English and in Bengali.

1. The levels

Children are placed into a level by a short screening (documents 01 and 02). A child can be in different levels for literacy and numeracy.

Level	Literacy (Bengali)	Numeracy
1	Holding a pencil, strokes and curves, vowel sounds with pictures and rhymes (doc 03)	Counting, number recognition, simple adding and taking away (screening Q1–Q2)
2	Building words, rhyme, vowel signs (kaar), hasanta, sounds (docs 04–06)	Face value, place value, two- and three-digit addition and subtraction (docs 07–08)
3	Conjunct letters, fluent reading, reciting poems (doc 06 and beyond)	Multiplication, division and word problems (docs 09–11)
Science	Classes 2–4: the sky, the Sun, the Moon and stars (docs 12 and 17)	

2. Document map

No.	Document	Use it for
01	Placement screening: numeracy	Deciding the numeracy level
02	Placement screening: Bengali literacy	Deciding the literacy level
03	Level 1 literacy, weeks 1–3	Strokes, curves, vowels and rhymes; tracing sheets
04	Level 2 literacy, week 1	Word building and rhymes (কল, জল, ...)
05	Level 2 literacy, week 2	Vowel signs (kaar) and hasanta
06	Level 2 literacy, week 3	Sounds, syllables and conjuncts
07	Level 2 numeracy, week 2	Face value, place value, addition
08	Level 2 numeracy, week 3	Three-digit numbers and subtraction

No.	Document	Use it for
09	Level 3 numeracy, week 1	Shopping word problem
10	Level 3 numeracy, week 2	Multiplication, story problem and riddle
11	Level 3 numeracy, week 3	Division
12	Science: the sky (classes 2–4)	Lesson plan and worksheets
13	Reference: Bengali alphabet, vowel signs and number words	Quick look-up for volunteers
14	Answer keys	Checking all worksheets
15	Games and activities bank	Warm-ups and spare activities
16	Tracker sheets and certificate	Attendance, progress, certificates
17	Sky extension activities	Shadow stick, Moon model, star stories

3. A good session in six steps

Step	Time	What happens
1	5 min	Welcome. Sit in a circle. Write each child's name on their sheet.
2	10 min	Revise last week with a quick game or oral questions (no writing).
3	15 min	New idea. Show first, then explain. Use objects, pictures and stories.
4	20 min	Practice on the worksheet. Children try first; you help after.
5	5 min	Share one answer from each child. Celebrate effort.
6	5 min	Give homework (only a few items). Tidy up. Say goodbye.

4. Teaching well

- **Show before you tell.** Use sticks, coins, cards, drawings and the board. Children understand what they can touch.
- **Ask, then wait.** After a question, count silently to ten. Let several children answer before you do.
- **Mistakes are useful.** Say "Good try, let's look together" and never "wrong". Ask the child to explain their thinking.
- **Speak the child's language.** Explain in Bengali or Hindi, or whatever the child speaks at home; use English words only after the idea is clear.
- **Little and often.** Ten minutes of doing beats thirty minutes of listening. Change activity when attention drops.
- **Praise effort, not only answers.** Avoid ranking children. Rewards (stickers, stars) should be for trying, finishing and helping others.

Making every child welcome

- Sit so that every child can see your face and the board. Check for children who may need glasses or who find it hard to hear.
- Some children find reading or number work hard for reasons that are not about effort. Give extra time, use big print and colour, and tell the team lead.
- Use respectful words for everyone. Avoid words that hurt (for example, do not use "কালা" for a person who cannot hear; say "বধির").
- Mix groups so that children who are quick can help (but not do the work for) children who are slower. Rotate roles: reader, writer, speaker, materials helper.
- Boys and girls, all communities and abilities take part equally. Choose examples and names that include everyone.

SAFETY AND CARE

- Work in pairs or in a place that others can see. Never be alone with one child.
- Never hit, shout at, shame or compare children.
- Take photos only if the organisers and the child's guardian have agreed in writing. Do not share names with photos.
- If a child tells you something that worries you (about safety or being hurt), stay calm, listen, do not promise to keep it secret, and tell the team lead straight away.
- Science activities use only safe materials. Never let children look directly at the Sun.

5. Moving between levels

Re-check a child after every three weeks, using the screening sheets or a few questions from the lesson. A child is ready to move up when they can do most items alone, without hints, on two different days. Moving up is a celebration, so tell the child and the family. A child who needs more time is not "behind": repeat with a different activity, not the same worksheet.

6. Materials checklist

Item	Used in
Printed worksheets (one per child) and a spare set	All sessions
Pencils (soft), erasers, crayons or colour pencils	Literacy, tracing
Ice-cream sticks (about 100), rubber bands, three small boxes labelled ×1, ×10, ×100	Place value, multiplication
Alphabet and letter cards (10 sets), number cards 0–9 (10 sets)	Literacy level 2
Play coins and notes (₹1, ₹10, ₹100)	Place value, shopping problems
Torch or phone light, a ball, a stick (30 cm), chalk	Science

Item	Used in
Stickers or stamps for encouragement	All sessions